PSCI 3350.001 Comparative Politics

Lecture 2: Democracy, democratization, and comparative history

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Today's puzzle

Why did some states enter the twentieth century with durable democratic institutions while others remained authoritarian or experienced democratic breakdown?

Two readings give us different parts of an answer:

- **Ishiyama** offers a historical explanation across six countries
- **Lijphart** shows how to evaluate comparisons when cases are few and causes are many

Learning goals

By the end of class, you should be able to:

1. Distinguish a democratic **threshold** from degrees of **polyarchy**
2. Explain Ishiyama's three historical conditions for democratization
3. Compare the six country trajectories using common questions
4. Diagnose the "many variables, small number of cases" problem
5. Turn a historical narrative into a testable comparative claim

Opening comparison

Britain

- Parliament constrained the Crown before industrialization
- Landed elites became commercially oriented
- Political inclusion widened gradually

Russia

- Autocracy remained dominant
- Serfdom and elite dependence persisted
- Reform arrived late and was reversed

Cold-call question: Which difference looks most causally important, and what evidence would change your mind?

Note: why did wool matter?

Rising Mediterranean demand for English wool changed English politics. Through what mechanism?

- Wool revenue let the Crown govern without summoning Parliament
- Wool needs much land and little labour, so landlords enclosed the commons
- Wool profits paid for the standing army the Stuarts wanted
- The wool trade imported Continental ideas about representation

The second. The asymmetry is the whole mechanism: **land mattered, labour did not** — so the peasantry was displaced and the nobility became commercial.

Part 1: The outcome to explain

Democracy has more than one definition

Schumpeter

Democracy is a method for selecting leaders through a **competitive struggle for votes**.

This is a narrow, procedural definition.

Held

Democracy requires **political equality** among members of the political community.

This is a more demanding standard.

The definition determines which cases count as democratic.

Dahl's polyarchy

Dahl treats democracy as an ideal and uses **polyarchy** for real political systems.

Competition

- Elected officials
- Free and fair elections
- Freedom of expression
- Alternative information
- Independent associations

Participation

- Broad suffrage
- Broad eligibility for office
- Equal consideration of preferences

Countries may improve on one dimension without improving equally on the other.

A democratic threshold

For the study of transitions, Ishiyama uses four minimum components drawn from Linz and Stepan and from Rose, Mishler, and Haerpfer.

Component	Diagnostic question
Rule of law	Are rulers bound by law?
Civil society	Can groups organize independently of the state?
Free and fair elections	Is there meaningful competition for office?
Accountability	Must governing officials answer for their actions?

No single component is sufficient. The combination identifies whether a regime has crossed a democratic threshold.

Two measures answer different questions

Concept	What it measures	Best question
Minimal democracy	A categorical threshold	Has the regime become democratic?
Polyarchy	Degrees of competition and participation	How democratic is the regime?

Democratization first establishes the minimum institutions, then can deepen competition and participation.

Note: why does Dahl need a second word?

Dahl reserves *democracy* for an ideal type and calls real systems **polyarchies**. Why?

- Because existing democracies differ from one another
- Because no actual system fully approximates the ideal
- Because the term applies only after a completed transition

The second. The ideal is a standard, not a description — **so every real case falls short of it, and the question becomes by how much**.

Part 2: Ishiyama's historical argument

Industrialization as a political shock

Industrialization changes more than production.

- New classes seek political influence
- Cities and markets unsettle older hierarchies
- States face demands for representation and protection
- Existing institutions must absorb or repress conflict

Ishiyama treats industrialization as a storm. The outcome depends partly on the political vessel constructed before the storm arrived.

Sequence is the central mechanism

Before

National identity, social order, and limits on rulers develop unevenly.

During

Industrialization creates new wealth, classes, conflicts, and demands.

After

Institutions incorporate new groups, break down, or harden into authoritarian rule.

The same economic shock can therefore produce different political outcomes.

Three historical conditions

1. **Political national identity** existed before industrialization
2. **Accountability and rule of law** constrained rulers before industrialization
3. The **feudal or old social order** had been transformed before industrialization

The argument is configurational. The conditions reinforce each other rather than operating as isolated causes.

Note: which one is not on the list?

Ishiyama organizes all six cases around three conditions established *before* industrialization. Which of these is **not** one of them?

- A mass national identity
- Accountability and the rule of law
- The old social order swept away
- An industrial working class organized into parties

The fourth. It sounds like something a chapter about industrialization ought to ask — **which is exactly why it is worth naming as absent**.

Political national identity

Ishiyama distinguishes cultural community from political unity.

Concept	Basis of membership
Kulturnation	Shared language, culture, religion, or ancestry
Staatsnation	Shared political institutions and a recognized political community

Cultural homogeneity does not automatically produce political integration. Japan was relatively homogeneous, yet its modern political identity had to be constructed.

Accountability before mass politics

The issue is not whether a country already had universal suffrage.

The issue is whether institutions had already established that:

- Rulers could be constrained
- Revenue and law required bargaining
- Organized interests could act outside the state
- Political conflict could occur within accepted institutions

Early accountability provided channels through which later demands could enter politics.

Transformation of the old order

A landed elite may respond to economic change in different ways.

Transformed elite

- Wealth becomes commercial
- Status depends less on hereditary privilege
- Elites can bargain within representative institutions

Persistent old order

- Land and labor remain coercively organized
- Elites depend on autocratic protection
- New groups threaten established privilege

The second path makes democratic inclusion more threatening to incumbent elites.

The argument as a causal chain

Stage	Historical question	Expected consequence
Community	Is there an accepted political nation?	Conflict stays within a shared polity
Constraint	Are rulers accountable under law?	New demands enter established channels
Social order	Has hereditary privilege been transformed?	Elites can tolerate broader participation
Industrial shock	How intense is social disruption?	Earlier arrangements face a stress test
Outcome	Are conflict and inclusion institutionalized?	Democracy, instability, or authoritarianism

Part 3: Six trajectories

Britain

- Political centralization and national integration developed early
- The wool economy and enclosure weakened the traditional peasantry
- Landed elites became commercially oriented
- Parliament defeated royal absolutism and secured rule-bound bargaining
- Suffrage expanded within an already accepted institutional arena

Democratization widened access to the stadium. It did not require constructing a new stadium during the crisis.

France

- Absolutism subordinated nobles and weakened independent accountability
- Labor-intensive agriculture preserved a large peasantry
- The Revolution destroyed noble privilege but did not produce immediate institutional consensus
- New social demands repeatedly met resistance outside stable channels
- Democratic development lurched through revolution, reaction, and constitutional redesign

France shows partial preparation followed by repeated institutional rupture.

Note: why did French feudalism survive?

England and France faced the same commercial opening. France did not transform. Why not?

- The Revolution destroyed the nobility before commercial agriculture could develop
- France entered international trade later, delaying commercial pressure
- French production was labour-intensive, so landlords kept peasants rather than shedding them
- There was no commercial demand for French agricultural products

The third. Viniculture and similar crops needed hands on the land. **Same pressure, opposite incentive, opposite outcome.**

United States

- Colonial assemblies established traditions of representation and accountability
- The country lacked European feudalism
- A unified political nation remained contested by sectional identity
- Slavery sustained hereditary racial privilege in the South
- Civil War settled the supremacy of the national state through violence

Institutions arrived early, but national political integration arrived late.

Germany

- Political fragmentation persisted into the nineteenth century
- The Junker elite retained power in Prussia
- Unification occurred through authoritarian state-building and war
- Industrialization outpaced democratization
- Weimar inherited deep cleavages, weak democratic commitment, war debt, and severe crisis

Rapid state formation did not produce an equally rapid democratic settlement.

Japan

- Tokugawa rule ended civil conflict but preserved decentralized feudal structures
- Meiji leaders constructed political identity around loyalty to the emperor
- The state directed modernization under external pressure
- Old domains and military traditions were adapted rather than fully displaced
- Durable democracy followed defeat and postwar institutional reconstruction

Japan separates cultural homogeneity from democratic political integration.

Russia

- Empire preceded a distinct modern national political community
- Loyalty centered on the Tsar and the state
- Autocracy destroyed or subordinated alternative centers of power
- Serfdom and a dependent nobility persisted
- Reform after 1905 left the Tsar's veto and dissolution powers intact
- War and state collapse opened the path to revolution rather than democracy

Russia is Ishiyama's sharpest contrast with Britain across all three historical conditions.

Six cases on common dimensions

Case	Political identity before industrialization	Accountability before industrialization	Transformation of old order	Broad trajectory
Britain	Strong	Strong	Extensive	Gradual inclusion
France	Partial	Weak	Partial	Repeated rupture
United States	Contested	Strong	Mixed because of slavery	Integration through civil war
Germany	Weak	Weak	Uneven	Authoritarian unification, fragile democracy
Japan	Constructed from above	Weak	Partial	State-led modernization, postwar democracy
Russia	Imperial loyalty	Very weak	Minimal	Autocracy, revolution

Paired contrast: Britain and France

Both countries experienced commercial change, state formation, and class conflict.

Similar background	Critical difference
Early European states	Parliament constrained the English Crown, while French absolutism prevailed
Powerful landed elites	English elites commercialized more fully, while French landlords retained peasant labor
Industrial and urban pressures	Britain incorporated groups gradually, while France repeatedly rebuilt institutions

This pairing directs attention to accountability and elite transformation.

Paired contrast: United States and Germany

Both were late projects of national political integration with strong regional divisions.

United States	Germany
Representative institutions preceded full national integration	Authoritarian unification preceded national democratic integration
No European feudal order, but slavery preserved hereditary privilege	Junker privilege persisted within the new state
Civil war consolidated national authority	External war consolidated an authoritarian empire

Similar problems of unity were processed through different institutions.

Paired contrast: Japan and Russia

Both pursued state-led modernization under autocratic authority.

- Political identity centered on personal loyalty to the sovereign
- Bureaucratic states promoted rapid economic and military change
- Older social and military hierarchies persisted
- Independent civil society and accountable institutions remained weak

The comparison suggests that modernization alone does not generate democracy.

Part 4: Lijphart's design audit

Four ways to study politics

Method	Cases	Control strategy
Experimental	Designed observations	Random assignment or direct manipulation
Statistical	Many	Estimate relationships while controlling for alternatives
Comparative	Few	Select and compare cases to approximate control
Case study	One	Generate, probe, confirm, or challenge theoretical claims

For Lijphart, the comparative method follows the same logic of control as statistical analysis, but with too few cases for conventional statistical control.

The central comparative problem

Many plausible explanatory variables, but only a small number of cases.

In Ishiyama's cases, democratic outcomes may reflect several factors at once.

- National identity
- Accountability
- Agrarian class structure
- Timing of industrialization
- War and defeat
- Religion
- State capacity
- International intervention

If several causes change together, a comparison cannot easily isolate one effect.

Four methods, one axis

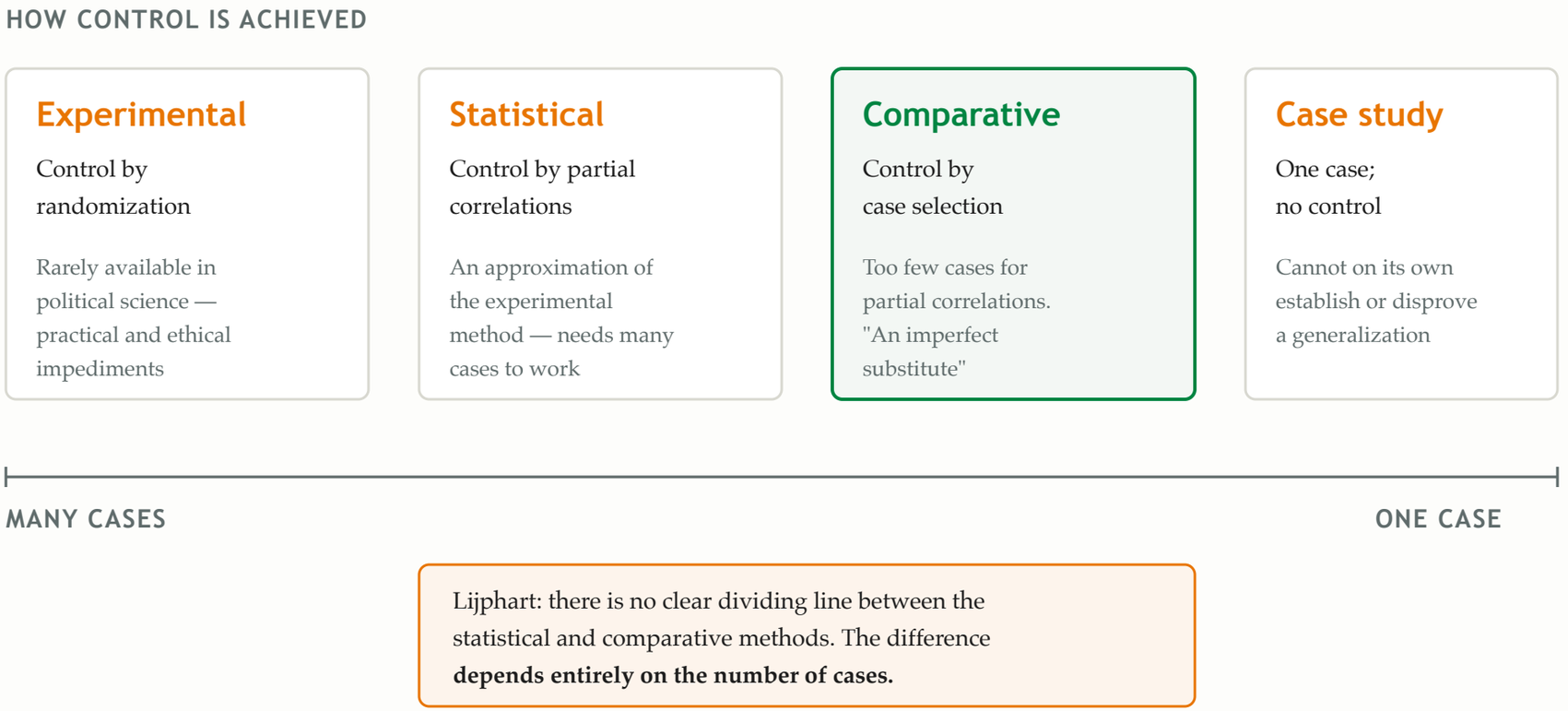


Figure 1: Lijphart's four basic methods, arranged by how many cases they work with and how each achieves control. Click to enlarge.

Note: what separates comparative from statistical?

Lijphart says the comparative method resembles the statistical method in every respect but one. Which one?

- The comparative method discovers relationships; the statistical method only measures them
- Its cases are too few to permit control through partial correlations
- It achieves control by deliberate randomization
- It is a narrow technique, while the statistical method is a general strategy

The second — and Lijphart goes further. There is **no clear dividing line** between them: **the difference depends entirely on the number of cases**.

Lijphart's four responses

Response	Practical move
Increase cases	Add countries, regions, or historical periods
Reduce property space	Combine related categories and variables
Select comparable cases	Hold background conditions as similar as possible
Focus on key variables	Prefer a parsimonious explanation

Each response improves leverage, but each also creates tradeoffs.

How Ishiyama addresses small N

Lijphart's response	Ishiyama's design
Increase cases	Uses six national histories rather than one
Reduce property space	Organizes diverse histories around three conditions
Select comparable cases	Builds paired contrasts with partly shared contexts
Focus on key variables	Emphasizes sequence before industrialization

The chapter gains clarity by simplifying history. That same simplification creates questions about omitted causes and scope.

Comparable means comparable for a question

Cases do not need to be identical.

They need to be similar on factors treated as controls and different on the factor believed to matter.

Stronger pairing

Britain and France for early state development, agrarian change, and constraints on rulers.

Harder pairing

Britain and Japan when geography, external pressure, timing, and institutional inheritance all differ.

Comparability is produced by the research question and the design.

What “comparable” looks like

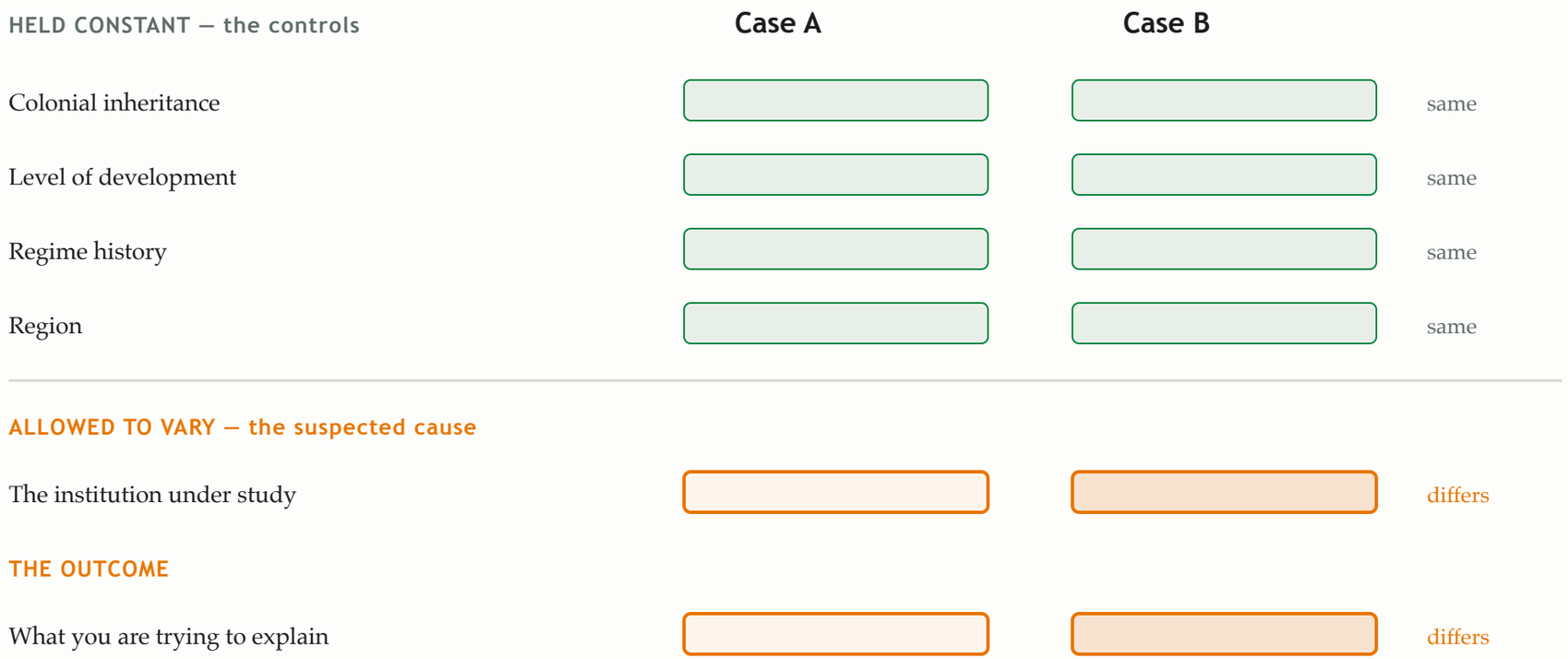


Figure 2: Comparable cases are alike on everything treated as a control and unlike on the suspected cause and the outcome. Click to enlarge.

Note: what makes two cases comparable?

- Similar in as many respects as possible, including the variables you want to relate
- Drawn from the same region, since areas supply natural controls
- Similar on many characteristics treated as constants, but different on the variables you want to relate
- Different in as many respects as possible, so a shared outcome must have a common cause

The third. **Cases that are similar in *every* respect would leave nothing to explain.**

Case studies can serve different purposes

Type	Role in theory
Atheoretical	Describes a case without engaging a broader proposition
Interpretive	Uses an existing theory to explain a case
Hypothesis-generating	Develops a new proposition from close study
Theory-confirming	Adds a case that fits an existing proposition
Theory-infirming	Adds a case that weakens confidence in a proposition
Deviant	Studies an unexpected case to refine the theory

Hypothesis-generating and deviant cases are especially useful for building better explanations.

Deviant cases refine probabilistic claims

Suppose the claim is:

> Early accountability usually increases the chance of durable democratization.

A case with early accountability and democratic failure matters, but it does not automatically disprove the claim.

Questions for the deviant case:

- Was accountability genuine or only formal?
- Did war or state collapse overwhelm the expected effect?
- Does the theory require another condition?
- Is the claim limited to a particular historical scope?

A design audit of the chapter

Explanatory gains

- Common questions discipline six narratives
- Historical sequence identifies plausible mechanisms
- Paired contrasts reveal meaningful differences
- Cases connect institutions to social structure

Remaining limits

- Cases are concentrated in major powers
- Several causes move together
- Outcome categories are broad
- The framework is strongly rooted in Western history

The comparison is valuable when its scope and uncertainty remain explicit.

Part 5: After the six cases

The Third Wave

Huntington coined the phrase in 1991. The wave began in the **mid-1970s** and gathered speed as the Cold War wound down and the Soviet Union collapsed.

Early optimism assumed that underdevelopment and other structural constraints would not impede democracy's spread.

> Haggard and Kaufman's summary of what actually happened: the net increase in the number of democracies **hid substantial churning**, with **a steady if small stream of reversions to authoritarian rule**.

Transitions to what?

Early work treated the puzzle as the **collapse of authoritarian rule** — the exit of incumbents, capped by founding elections.

But many Third Wave transitions produced regimes that fell short of democracy on any broader definition:

- **Competitive authoritarian** (Levitsky and Way) · **illiberal** · **electoral authoritarian** · **hybrid**

Elections held, limited political space, but a playing field the incumbent defines.

> These are not way stations. A growing recognition is that competitive authoritarianism **may be a persistent equilibrium in its own right**.

When two datasets disagree

Cheibub et al. (2010)

Minimalist and dichotomous: free elections plus turnover

65 transitions identified

Polity Project

Continuous, −10 to +10: executive recruitment, constraints, participation

agree on 55.4%

the rest do not match

THE LESSON

Two respected datasets.
The same phenomenon.
Barely half agreement.

Name your measure,
and say why.

21 of 65 of the transitions Cheibub counts score below 6 on Polity — closer to competitive authoritarianism than to democracy.

Figure 3: Cheibub et al. and the Polity Project code the same phenomenon and agree on barely half of it. Click to enlarge.

Structure returned, but without mechanisms

As optimism about "crafting" democracy ebbed, **structural theories** came back: level of development, inequality, resource endowments, ethnic and religious heterogeneity.

But the findings are mixed almost everywhere you look:

Structural claim	What the evidence does
Inequality drives transitions	Boix finds support; Houle, Ahlquist and Wibbels, and Haggard and Kaufman find no significant relationship
Resource wealth blocks democracy	Contested; Haber and Menaldo find no relationship, and selection bias cuts against the standard test
Ethnic fragmentation destabilizes democracy	Few tests exist; Fish and Brooks, and Fish and Kroenig, find effects disappear with development

Haggard and Kaufman's diagnosis: the enduring weakness of these theories is **inattention to the mechanisms** linking structure to regime change.

Development: which question?

Transitions

Does development cause authoritarian regimes to democratize?

Contested. Przeworski et al. argued it does not; Boix and Stokes challenged them using a longer time frame.

Consolidation

Does development help democracies survive?

Much stronger consensus. Przeworski et al.: no democracy had ever reverted above a per capita income of **$6,055** — Argentina's level in 1975.

Same variable, two questions, **two very different states of knowledge**. Which question you ask decides what the literature can tell you.

No taproot

Haggard and Kaufman's central methodological claim: the quest for an **overarching theory** of democratization — a taproot — is **probably misguided**.

Even well-supported cross-national generalizations must accommodate **numerous anomalies**. Their prescription:

- **Combinations** of causal factors rather than single causes
- **Alternative pathways** to the same outcome
- **Equifinality** — different routes, same destination

Notice what this is not. It is not a call for more data. **It is a claim that the assumption of one causal path is the problem.**

The same conclusion, from two directions

Lijphart, 1971

Too many variables, too few cases. Control by selecting cases; be modest about what one comparison can establish.

Haggard and Kaufman, 2016

Large-N work yields anomalies. Look for combinations, pathways, equifinality; use qualitative work on necessary and sufficient conditions.

Forty-five years apart, working from opposite ends of the N, and they arrive at the same place: **a single general law of democratization is not what this field is going to produce**.

Note: what follows from "no taproot"?

Haggard and Kaufman argue the search for an overarching theory is misguided. What do they conclude the field should do?

- Build larger cross-national datasets, since samples are too small to detect the true effect
- Attend to combinations of causal factors, alternative pathways, and equifinality
- Move to formal models that specify precise conditions
- Agree on one measure of democracy, since disagreement is mostly definitional

The second. **More data would not help if the problem is the assumption of a single path.**

Note: development and democracy

On development, where is the consensus in the literature **stronger**?

- Transitions — development reliably causes authoritarian regimes to democratize
- Consolidation — development is associated with democracies surviving
- Neither, since the correlation disappears once region is controlled
- Resource wealth specifically, now agreed to be the decisive form of development

The second. The transition question remains contested; **the survival question is where the evidence is strongest**.

Part 6: From reading to research

A claim-evidence map

Element	Example
Claim	Early constraints on rulers make later democratic inclusion more durable.
Mechanism	New groups can pursue demands through accepted institutions rather than extra-institutional conflict.
Evidence for	Britain had parliamentary constraint before industrialization and expanded participation gradually.
Comparative evidence	France developed under absolutism and repeatedly experienced rupture during inclusion.
Rival explanation	Different agrarian class structures, not accountability, drove the contrast.
Discriminating evidence	Compare cases with similar agrarian structures but different levels of early accountability.
Scope	European states undergoing early industrialization.

Team comparison workshop

For the focal country and shadow comparator:

1. Record each country's value on Ishiyama's three historical conditions
2. Identify one outcome that differs between the countries
3. State one causal claim that could explain the difference
4. Name one rival explanation
5. Identify evidence that would distinguish the two explanations

The goal is not to find two identical countries. The goal is to make the basis of comparison explicit.

A stronger team presentation

An effective weekly presentation includes:

- One comparative puzzle
- One explicit causal claim
- Evidence from both countries
- One rival explanation
- One limitation of the comparison
- One question for the class

The presenters defend the comparison. The class serves as the design review panel.

History constrains without determining

Ishiyama rejects a mechanical reading of the argument.

- Long-term structures shape the options available to leaders
- Critical moments still involve political choices
- Institutions can redirect inherited conflict
- External shocks can alter trajectories

> Historical conditions change probabilities. They do not write an unavoidable political future.

Note: constraint or destiny?

Ishiyama cites Sartori to warn against one reading of the six cases. Which?

- Historical factors describe background conditions but explain nothing
- Democracy was the product of human choices at critical moments, though choices were constrained
- Every case is unique, so comparison cannot support generalization
- Institutions matter only after a country has crossed the democratic threshold

The second. Democracy "did not just happen, nor was it predetermined by history or culture" — **but leaders cannot engineer it where no social or economic base supports it**.

Core takeaways

1. Definitions determine the outcome we are trying to explain
2. Ishiyama emphasizes the sequence of identity, accountability, and social transformation before industrialization
3. The six histories become comparable only when organized by common questions
4. Lijphart identifies the central weakness of the design: many causes and few cases
5. Pairing, parsimony, rival explanations, and deviant cases can strengthen comparative inference